

NEED FOR SPEED CARBON

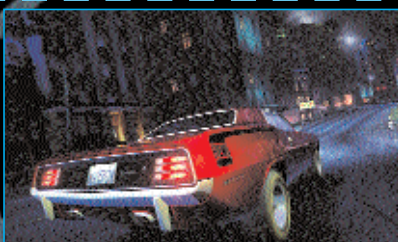
One Small Step For Games...

The Factory, previously known to the world as Electronic Arts, has struck again. The *Need for Speed* franchise never seems to get tired, setting a benchmark so high that few arcade racers come close, much less threaten the games' obvious superiority. With *Need for Speed: Carbon* (NFSC), EA brings to us a stew of the best of its predecessors, and then some.

The Story

The game starts off where *NFS: Most Wanted* ended—your unceremonious return to your old city of Palmont. A flashback also ensues, informing you that you high-tailed it to Rockport in the first place because you ticked a bunch of people off plenty. You must now redeem yourself in the eyes of your former peers, not to mention one highly cheesed-off ex-girlfriend (played by the hot-but-not-Josie-Maran Emanuele Vaugier). You need to take over the territories of the other gangs in the city, bringing back the old sense of order (?) that you left behind. If you can't figure out how, perhaps you should read a different review.

The story (and I use the term very loosely) progresses in the mixture of full-motion video and CG that *Most Wanted* brought to us. Unfortunately, while the acting in *Most Wanted* was hilariously tacky, the acting in this one rivals the movie industry's prize turkeys.



Which Door?

When you start off, you get to choose from three car classes—the Muscles, Exotics, and Tuners—each with its own advantages and quirks. The Muscles are insanely powerful and slide like oil on a banana skin, the Exotics are natural supercars, and the Tuners offer an embarrassing number of customisations. The Muscles are undoubtedly the most entertaining—and if you can handle a Muscle car, you can handle anything. Overall, though, the cars handle pretty much the same way as in *Most Wanted*—rock solid, but with sufficient variations to keep you entertained.

Mi Amigo!

The first addition to NFSC is the crew—your wingmen, who will help you out in your races. You can choose only one per race—either a blocker, drafter, or scout. Blockers will (duh) block your opponents from threatening you, drafters will let you ride in their slipstream for a boost in speed and scouts ride in front of you, marking off the fastest way through the track. The addition is neat, but your wingman's constant chatter can get on your nerves, and strangely, he always manages to come ride next to you the second you take the lead.

Pretty Pretty?

NFSC's Palmont is a grey city, whose well-lit night-time environments really

